ESPI European Space Policy Institute

Annual Report 2025

A year of disruption:
CHANGE OF POSTURE

ESPI MEMBERS

Founding Members:

FFG Promoting Innovation. esa

Supported by:

Federal Ministry Innovation, Mobility and Infrastructure Republic of Austria

REGULAR MEMBERS
States, international organisations and institutions that perform almost exclusively the tasks of states or international organisations – or are active in the field of space administration and are normally tasked with representing a state on space matters.

CORPORATE MEMBERS
Private and public space companies and other commercial enterprises in the space sector and related areas.

Regular Members

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XJENZA MALTA
European Commission
AEE Agencia Espacial Española
Belgian Science Policy Office belspo
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ThalesAlenia Space a Thales / Leonardo company
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Statement from the Director of ESPI

H. Ludwig Moeller

Dear readers, European stakeholders, and international partners,

As we release our annual report, we find ourselves at a moment that celebrates togetherness. A photograph of humans orbiting the Moon, with Earth shining above the lunar horizon, symbolises what can connect people globally. At the same time, war in Europe continues, and new threats of war are propagated with potentially devastating consequences for Europe and for the whole world.

These developments provide further evidence that Europe must take responsibility for its own destiny, bravely stand up for its values and for peace. Europe must work closely with trusted partners globally, on Earth and in space.

Already in 2024, ESPI predicted that the unique geopolitical disruptions would trigger a new level of ambition for increased sovereignty in Europe. It also foresaw that the European Space Agency (ESA) Ministerial Council would be a moment of truth. *And it was.*

Today, we can confidently say that Europe is changing its posture, as it is responding to global uncertainties from East and West. These challenges arise from long-standing partners, emerging powers and new challengers. They also bring unique opportunities. Europe's commitment to multilateral cooperation in space has been increasing further, as 23 member states entrusted ESA with the highest budget in its 50-year history. At the same time, individual countries such as Germany, Spain and Poland multiplied their investment in space, and the next EU funding cycle is expected to further grow its space budget component significantly.

ESPI AGENDA

As Europe has been stepping up, 2025 has also been a decisive year for ESPI. The Austrian Ministry of Foreign and European Affairs granted ESPI the status of Quasi-International Organisation (QuIO), marking the most significant institutional milestone in the history of the Institute.

At the same time, the Institute has been able to secure its future and independence through several bilateral agreements with its members. This includes the completion of the first year of the renewed agreement for 2025-2028 with the Federal Ministry of Innovation, Mobility and Infrastructure (BMIMI) of Austria, an agreement with Luxembourg Space Agency for 2025-2029 and a renewed agreement with ESA for 2026-2028 approved by all members of the ESA Council. Moreover, the Institute had the honour to welcome two new governmental members: the Spanish Space Agency (AEE) and Xjenza Malta.

ESPI stands stronger than ever, as it will further accelerate the promotion of European space policy on a global level. The Institute will carry the policy debate well beyond the traditional perimeter of the space ecosystem into the digital economy, national security, transport, energy and other sectors. Amplifying its status as QuIO, ESPI will invest new efforts to increase public awareness and to connect space and society.

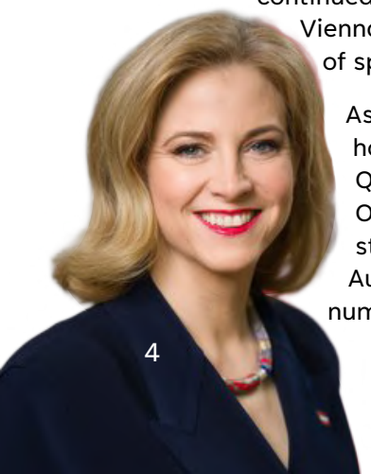
Statements from ESPI Co-founders

Federal Minister for European and International Affairs of the Republic of Austria

H.E. Beate Meinl-Reisinger

Federal Ministry
European and
International Affairs
Republic of Austria

Austria is a strong advocate for the peaceful use of outer space. Austria has long been a trusted bridge-builder in international space diplomacy, with Vienna serving as a neutral hub for dialogue on space law and policy. Today, Vienna provides a home to the world's most influential space organisations, the United Nations Office for Outer Space Affairs (UNOOSA) and the Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space (COPUOS). Since 2003, this includes ESPI, which has become an important part of the global space community. It is therefore a great pleasure to welcome you to the 2025 Annual Report of the European Space Policy Institute, a year marked by major institutional evolution for ESPI and continued ESPI engagement in Vienna, the world capital of space diplomacy.



As of July 2025, ESPI holds the status of a Quasi-International Organisation. This status, granted by Austria to a limited number of NGOs, reflects ESPI's growing importance at a time of profound geopolitical and geoeconomic change. It will empower ESPI's role as a European actor and trusted partner internationally.

We live in an era where space is no longer a niche technical domain but a critical infrastructure and a transformative enabler of foreign policy, security, and economic resilience. ESPI's independent research and analysis provides the solid foundation necessary for evidence-based decision making at both the national and European level. By highlighting the political impact of space and its effects on our daily lives, ESPI helps us navigate the "strategic gaps" of the 21st century and ensures that European space policy remains proactive rather than reactive.

As Minister of Foreign Affairs of Austria, I am proud that we have a vibrant space community here in Vienna, thanks to UNOOSA and ESPI. Austria remains steadfast in its commitment to strengthening ESPI's role in support of space diplomacy for prosperity, peace and future generations.

Director General of the European Space Agency

Josef Aschbacher

Dear members of ESPI, dear European space community, dear international partners,

As global roles shift, Europe remains a trusted and reliable partner on the international space stage. Space is not a sector among others. It is the backbone of modern societies. The year 2025 saw a clear upscale of this ambition with ESA and its Member States taking new posture at the 2025 Ministerial Council. As one of the founding members, ESA is proud to see ESPI's role acknowledged at the highest political level, with the Government of Austria granting the status of a Quasi-International Organisation to ESPI in July 2025. This recognition will further support ESPI's activities to promote European space policy globally, as Europe's independent think tank for space.

ESPI complements ESA's mandate by providing the intellectual infrastructure that underpins long-term strategic thinking. In 2025, I had the privilege to engage with ESPI and its staff in several instances, including at ESPI's 19th Autumn Conference, the Space for European Resilience Conference, or the Plenary Session of the Estonian Presidency of the European Interparliamentary Space Conference.

At ESA's Ministerial Council meeting in 2025, Member States took historical decisions to elevate Europe's space ambition. Related to this, I am delighted to see growing appreciation of ESPI's value by ESA Member States through a new ESA-ESPI Agreement for the period 2026-2028 with increased ESA support to ESPI. This bears testimony to the fact that ESPI's work strengthens Europe's collective capacity to anticipate challenges, align national and institutional perspectives, and inform evidence-based decisions in the space domain.

Dear friends of ESPI, the world is witnessing a profound shift in the political and industrial balance of power in space and beyond. ESA and its Member States are ensuring that Europe remains a strong, reliable, and forward-looking space power delivering tangible benefits for citizens while inspiring the next generation. I look forward to strengthening our collaboration with ESPI in this shared ambition.

HIGHLIGHTS

CHAPTER ONE

Space power
REINFORCING POLITICAL MOMENTUM FOR SPACE IN EUROPE

Industrial vision
RECLAIMING EUROPE'S EDGE IN SPACE

It takes a village
HUMAN INTERACTION IN THE AGE OF AI

Leadership through partnership
EUROPE AS A STRONG PARTNER TO THE WORLD

1 Space power

REINFORCING POLITICAL MOMENTUM FOR SPACE IN EUROPE

In 2025, Europe saw a significant shift in its space ambition, a true change of posture. ESPI's work further informed the political debate and helped define Europe's level of ambition.

BUILDING ALIGNMENT AROUND THE VISION OF EUROPE AS A FULLY FLEDGED SPACE POWER

Is Europe a space power? This was the central question to ESPI's Annual Conference this year. The Institute's annual flagship event, held at Vienna City Hall, brought together over 300 participants from 62 nations. It was a space conference about policy and power, a step towards claiming a leading European role on the global stage, beyond statements of ambition to Europe's true political will.

The conference staged three thematic debates:

Building power – underlining that political will in Europe to fully leverage space for peace and economy has reached a new level that would have been inconceivable just a year ago.

Building bridges – reflecting growing expectations from international partners for Europe to step up its global role, act as a leading and trusted partner and serve as a role model.

Pillars of space power - zooming in on key capabilities of global space powers - human space exploration, space for security and defence, innovation power and industrial competitiveness.

"Building power" session at the 19th ESPI Annual Conference, featuring a policy dialogue with politicians

The 19th ESPI Annual Conference was hosted for the first time at Vienna City Hall and welcomed attendees of more than 60 nationalities

SHAPING THE EUROPEAN SPACE STRATEGY

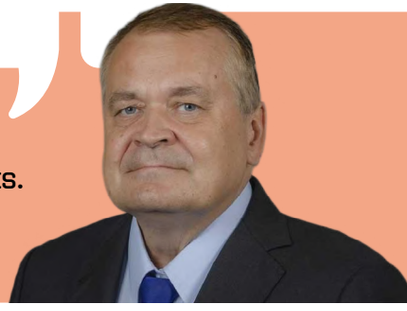
In 2025, ESPI released the report ***"An Initial Perspective on a European Space Strategy 2040: From Vision Towards Implementation"***. The report called for a European strategy that gives new emphasis to narratives on the policy value of space and its benefits for society, and places at its core two dimensions:

- Security and defence, as well as the military component the report calls us to also consider the protection of critical infrastructure, food security and economic resilience.
- Economy, to address economic benefits beyond the space sector more fully.

A CLEAR CALL FOR EUROPE TO SCALE UP

Since 2023, ESPI has consistently argued that Europe must raise its investment in space to at least 0.15% of European GDP — effectively doubling the efforts. By 2025, this objective edged closer to reality, supported by major political announcements, including Germany's €35 billion space-related defence budget and a remarkable 32% increase in ESA's Council at Ministerial Level 2025 (CM25) subscriptions to €22.3 billion.

> European Commission's ambitions in space are high, but success requires joint effort. Together with the Member States, European Space Agency, EUSPA, ESPI, and the whole space industrial ecosystem, we must fully exploit all available programmes and financial instruments.
>
> **Timo Pesonen**
> DIRECTOR-GENERAL AT DG DEFIS, EUROPEAN COMMISSION



2 Industrial vision
RECLAIMING EUROPE'S EDGE IN SPACE

In 2025, ESPI strengthened its role as a convener between policy and industry. Unlike in many other sectors, Europe still has the opportunity to reclaim its industrial edge in space, as long as it acts with bravery and intent.

A NEW INDUSTRIAL VISION FOR EUROPE

ESPI's report, ***"Blinded by the Light",*** called Europe to widen the political debate on reclaiming Europe's industrial edge in space. It put speed, agility and innovation at the core, as the most critical markers for success in a global space race, next to scale. The report also argues that competitiveness and autonomy need each other, one cannot be sustainable without the other.

Only with a thriving and competitive space industry can Europe futureproof its defence, supercharge innovation, and boost its champions in the digital economy and in globally competitive sectors.

A series of industry workshops in Luxembourg and Berlin informed ESPI's work on a new industrial vision for Europe

WORKING HANDS-ON WITH INDUSTRY

Through a series of dedicated workshops and industry consultations, ESPI brought together established players, SMEs and emerging innovators to examine the future of Europe's industrial base. These engagements informed the *"Blinded by the Light"* report.

INCREASING THE APPETITE OF THE DEFENCE INDUSTRY TO EMBED SPACE

The 2025 study, ***"Rising Together? The (Re)Convergence of Europe's Space and Defence Industries"***, underlined that while traditional space companies are increasingly called on to boost European security and defence, pure defence companies are also (re) venturing into the space domain, through new programmes, acquisitions, and investment.

In the report ***"Blinded by the Light"***, ESPI argued Europe still has all it takes to reclaim its edge in space, as long as it acts with bravery and intent

SECURING EUROPE'S TALENT BASE

The 2025 study ***"Talent in the European Space Sector: Bridging Gaps, Building Futures"*** shed light on Europe's workforce challenges, highlighting shortages in critical technical skills, limited mobility opportunities and growing competition for talent. ESPI's findings emphasised that without a strong and adaptable workforce, Europe's industrial ambition cannot be realised.

FROM THE SPACE INDUSTRY TO THE DIGITAL ECONOMY

In the report ***"Data centres in space: orbital backbone of the second digital era?"***, ESPI identified space-based data centres as a significant and rapidly emerging opportunity for Europe's digital and space industries. The infrastructure that will power humanity's digital future is being designed today and Europe must decide whether it will shape that future or follow it.

> Europe's space industry is transforming; geographically, structurally, and in the partnerships it pursues with defence and digital actors. Public institutions will be judged by their ability to nurture and, above all, leverage these commercial dynamics.
>
> **Matija Renčelj**
> DIRECTOR OF STRATEGY & OPERATIONS AT ESPI

Highlight

3 It takes a village
HUMAN INTERACTION IN THE AGE OF AI

"The Policy Value of Earth Observation" workshop at the Royal Society in London convened active members of parliament, former ministers, high-level EU executives, thought leaders, policy experts, financiers, and space experts from across Europe

In 2025, ESPI highlighted the wider political, economic and societal impact of space by strengthening its engagement with communities that shape Europe's future and can benefit from space — from parliamentarians and diplomats to journalists, artists and future generations.

A POLICY VISION FOR EARTH OBSERVATION THAT SERVES SOCIETY

ESPI deepened its work on the policy value of Earth observation, examining how it supports society in essential domains such as food, water, energy, democracy and peace. The policy vision for Earth observation released at the Living Planet Symposium 2025 set a direction, initiating a dialogue to maximise Earth observation's policy impact.

Annual Summer Reception of ESPI's Vienna Space Diplomat initiative hosted by Spain

STRENGTHENING DEMOCRATIC DIALOGUE WITH PARLIAMENTARIANS

2025 marked the first full year of ESPI's reinforced role as secretariat of the European Interparliamentary Space Conference (EISC), building on 15 years of close cooperation. ESPI supported parliamentary engagement throughout the Estonian EISC Presidency, reinforcing the role of parliamentarians in shaping Europe's space agenda.

ENGAGING THE DIPLOMATIC COMMUNITY THROUGH THE VIENNA SPACE DIPLOMAT INITIATIVE

ESPI continued to serve as an anchor for the diplomatic community in Vienna through its Vienna Space Diplomat initiative. Regular events brought together ambassadors, international organisations and diplomatic missions to debate topics such as climate resilience, space security and sustainability.

"Space Provocations" event for broader audiences, including the next generation, at the Universe Pavillion during the 2025 Biennale di Venezia

ESTABLISHING THE CENTRE FOR SUSTAINABILITY AND RESILIENCE AT ESPI

With support of its host nation, Austria, ESPI established the new Centre for Sustainability and Resilience (CSR) in 2025, a community-facing platform within and beyond the space sector. The Centre focuses on the role of space in addressing sustainability and resilience challenges for European societies and economies.

CONNECTING SPACE WITH ART AND CULTURE

ESPI broadened its outreach to cultural audiences through partnerships with the arts community, highlighting the inspirational power of space. In 2025, ESPI welcomed its first artist-in-residence for space policy, Kyriaki Goni, and contributed to programming connected to the Venice Biennale, at the "Universe Pavillion" with the support from ESPI member Exolaunch and the Bertelsmann Foundation.

> We're facing new times — times that demand we process more information and do so faster. Earth observation is a strategic tool to solve real challenges in security, defence, and sustainability. These times require us to align, act and accelerate new policies together with research and innovation initiatives.
>
> **Manuel Heitor**
> FORMER MINISTER FOR SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY & HIGHER EDUCATION OF PORTUGAL; FOUNDER OF IN+ (CENTER FOR INNOVATION, TECHNOLOGY & POLICY RESEARCH)

Leadership through partnership:

EUROPE NEEDS TO BE A STRONG TRUSTED PARTNER TO THE WORLD.
ESPI'S INTERNATIONAL ENGAGEMENT ACTIVITIES SUPPORT THIS AMBITION.

Cooperation with the Universe Pavillion during the 2025 Biennale in Venice, Italy

ESPI-BFNA-IOG lunar foresight workshop in Tokyo, Japan

Long-term cooperation between ESPI and APRSAF reinforced in the APRSAF annual meeting in Cebu, Philippines

Continued engagement at the International Astronautical Congress in Sydney, Australia

H.E. Dr. Tidiane Ouattara from African Space Agency speaking at the 19th ESPI Annual Conference

ESPI's Space Venture panel at the SPACETIDE conference in Tokyo, Japan

Welcoming Seorim Lee, Visiting Expert from the Korea Aerospace Research Institute (KARI) at ESPI in Vienna, Austria

Perspectives from India, Thailand and Saudi Arabia at the 19th ESPI Annual Conference

Community engagement at ESPI on the occasion of the 40th Living Planet Symposium in Vienna, Austria

ESPI delegation at the 40th Space Symposium in Colorado, United States of America

Meeting with representatives from Japan's Cabinet Office in Tokyo, Japan

ESPI Lead for Exploration and Science Lars Petzold at the Global Conference on Space Exploration (GLEX) in New Delhi, India

"Innovation Beauty Inspiration" event at ESPI, connecting astronauts (Luca Parmitano) with the fashion world (Prada)

Europe and Japan are bound by shared values - transparency, sustainability, and the peaceful use of space - but also by a common ambition: to build something greater than either could achieve alone. As the ISS era draws to a close and international cooperation narrows globally, this partnership must rise to fill the void. Think tanks play a quiet but vital role here, cultivating the strategic trust and long-term vision that governments and agencies need to turn shared values into shared infrastructure - and shared destiny.

Jun Kazeki
DIRECTOR-GENERAL FOR NATIONAL SPACE POLICY SECRETARIAT AT THE CABINET OFFICE OF THE JAPANESE GOVERNMENT

CHAPTER TWO

ESPI by the numbers

European engagement

Global reach

Education

Key publications

Highlights across the thematic research areas:

- GREEN AND SUSTAINABLE SOCIETIES
- SECURITY AND DEFENCE
- EXPLORATION AND SCIENCE
- INDUSTRY, INNOVATION, FINANCE AND WORKFORCE
- SPACE AS AN ASSET

OUR IMPACT

ESPI by the Numbers

	2023 Data	2024 Data	2025 Data
Total Website Users	9,839	11,055	13,803
Total LinkedIn Followers	12,768	17,120	22,967
Total LinkedIn Views	435,000	540,000	793,850

Growth Rates

Website Users
+25%

LinkedIn Followers
+34%

LinkedIn Views
+47%

45+
Publications

160+
Events with active role

European engagement

In 2025, ESPI continued to deepen its engagement across Europe, strengthening bilateral relationships with national authorities, supporting key institutional processes, and expanding its membership base.

ESA – At the 2025 ESA Council at Ministerial level, ESA and ESPI signed a new agreement for the 2026-2028 period, including increased ESA support to the Institute.

BELGIUM – ESPI launched a new research collaboration with BELSPO, further strengthening ties with one of the Institute's long-standing members.

DENMARK – ESPI cooperated with Danish EU Council Presidency and ESA on the Space for European Resilience Conference in Brussels, Belgium.

ESTONIA – ESPI supported Estonia's Presidency of the European Interparliamentary Space Conference, including for the two sessions in Tartu and Talinn.

GERMANY – ESPI organised two media roundtables in Berlin in cooperation with the German Space Agency (DLR).

ITALY – Under its multi-year Memorandom of Understanding (MoU) with the Italian Space Agency (ASI), ESPI increased ASI's secondments to the Institute to two.

LUXEMBOURG – ESPI signed a bilateral agreement with the Luxembourg Space Agency (LSA), marking a new chapter in the cooperation between the two organisations.

MALTA – Xjenza Malta, Malta's national research, development and space funding agency, joined ESPI as a new member.

NORWAY – ESPI hosted a Norwegian Space Agency young graduate trainee for a research stay at ESPI premises in Vienna.

POLAND –ESPI cooperated with the Polish Space Agency (POLSA) and the Polish EU Council Presidency on the 3rd ESA Security Conference in Warsaw.

SLOVENIA – Following Slovenia's accession to ESA, ESPI deepened engagement with Slovenian government, to support the country's strengthened cooperation in space policy.

SPAIN – The Spanish Space Agency (AEE) joined ESPI as a new member, following the signing of a MoU between the two organisations in September 2023.

UK – ESPI established the Roy Gibson Fellowship with the support of the UK Space Agency and ESA, creating the opportunity to support targeted policy. ESPI also contributed to the House of Lords inquiry on "The space economy: act now or lose out".

The 2025 presidency of the European Interparliamentary Space Conference (EISC) was held by Estonia, chaired by MP Mario Kadastik (centre). ESPI has been supporting EISC, and its 15 member parliaments, since 2009 and serves as the secretariat to the Conference.

STRENGTHENING ESPI'S PRESENCE IN BRUSSELS

Throughout 2025, ESPI continued to leverage the presence of an ESPI representative in Brussels by participating in several key institutional processes, including a presentation to the European Parliament's ITRE Committee and a contribution to the European Economic and Social Committee (EESC). Through a series of dedicated events and major presence at the European Space Conference, ESPI reinforced its role as an active voice in space policy debate in Brussels.

NEST ANNUAL MEETING

The Network of European Space Policy Think Tanks (NEST) held its annual meeting alongside the ESPI Annual Conference, bringing together think tanks from across Europe.

ESPI Representative in Brussels Sara Dalledonne delivers a presentation on the EU Space Act at the meeting of European Parliament's ITRE Committee

> We are very satisfied with our incorporation into the European Space Policy Institute (ESPI), the world's leading space 'think tank'. This membership represents another step that underscores Spain's commitment to space.
>
> **Juan Carlos Cortés**
> DIRECTOR OF THE SPANISH SPACE AGENCY (AEE) AND INCOMING CHAIR OF THE ESA COUNCIL

ESPI'S GLOBAL REACH

EUROPE AS A STRONG PARTNER TO THE WORLD

In 2025, ESPI continued to expand its global footprint, deepening partnerships across major regions and reinforcing its role as a convener of international space policy dialogue.

NORTH AMERICA

ESPI increased its presence at the 40th Space Symposium in the United States of America. It also deepened cooperation with the Bertelsmann Foundation, through a series workshops on lunar exploration and with Aerospace Corporation, through joint research on commercial procurement. Engagement with Canada also grew, marked by high-level Canadian Space Agency participation in the ESPI Annual Conference.

LATIN AMERICA

ESPI hosted its 2nd Inter-Regional Space Policy Dialogue with Latin America and the Caribbean (GRULAC) in Vienna, building on the inaugural dialogue held in 2024 and further strengthening the exchange between European and Latin American space policy communities.

ESPI's Vienna Space Diplomat (VSD) initiative continued to grow in 2025, consolidating its recognition as diplomatic engagement platform on space policy in Vienna. Throughout the year, VSD convened six events, including the annual reception hosted by the Spanish Permanent Mission, welcoming hundreds of attendees from permanent missions and international organisations to discuss topics ranging from space security and sustainability to Earth observation and the strategic value of space.

VSD
VIENNA SPACE DIPLOMAT

AFRICA

ESPI contributed to the NewSpace Africa Conference and to the African Space Leadership Institute, while the participation of H.E. Dr. Tidiane Ouattara at the ESPI Annual Conference underscored the Institute's commitment to support the increased integration of African perspectives into global space policy discussions.

ASIA-PACIFIC

ESPI strengthened partnerships across the region through engagements in Japan, Korea and Australia, including contributions to SPACETIDE, a keynote at a KASS event, and hosting visiting researchers from KARI and MEXT. ESPI also led the 5th Inter-Regional Space Policy Dialogue at APRSAF, reinforcing this series as a core element of its Asia-Pacific outreach.

Education

TO NURTURE AND CONTRIBUTE TO A STRONGER, BETTER CONNECTED, AND MORE EFFECTIVE SPACE EDUCATION ECOSYSTEM IN EUROPE

ESPI acknowledges that the space sector's workforce, a cornerstone in supporting the sector's rapid technological and structural evolution needs, must constantly evolve and adapt to meet these needs.

A NEW TRAINING SCHOOL FOR JOURNALISTS

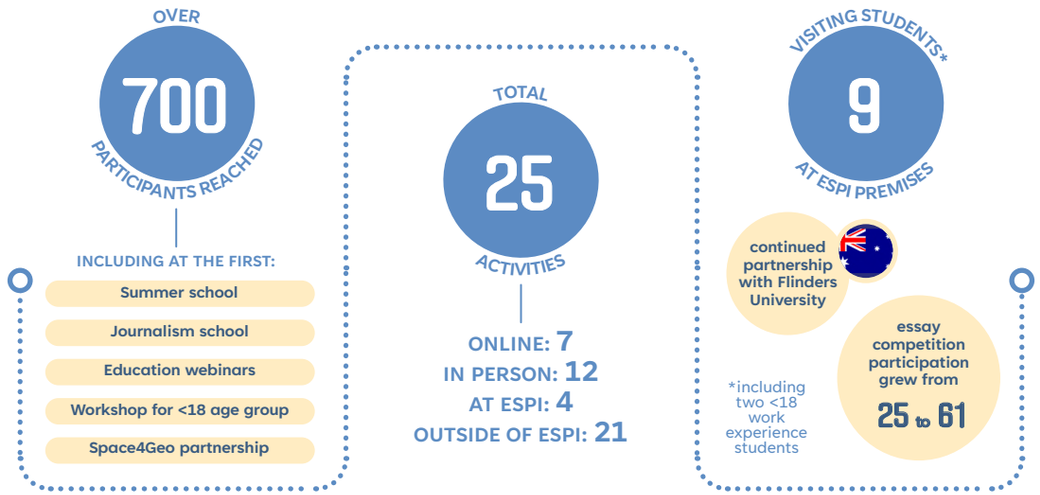
ESPI organised its first ***European Journalism Training School*** in collaboration with Scuola di Giornalismo Luiss, Luiss Data Lab and Frediano Finucci. Welcoming 20 selected journalists and media professionals from Europe and Africa, the course equipped them with the skills and knowledge needed to navigate the complexities of space industry and its societal and economic impacts.

WORKSHOP WITH YOUNG STUDENTS

As part of the Institute's commitment to education, ESPI broadened its scope in 2025 by launching its first youth-focused education workshop. The initiative convened 30 students for a collaborative exercise centred on designing a new civilisation on an exoplanet, encouraging early engagement with space policy and space science topics.

ROY GIBSON FELLOWSHIP

This year, the Roy Gibson Fellowship was launched, a joint ESPI, ESA and UK Space Agency initiative. Named in honour of Roy Gibson, the first Director General of ESA, the fellowship recognises the critical importance of space policy and diplomacy in times of unprecedented geopolitical and geoeconomic shifts, which also affect space. The research focus of the 2025/26 edition is: ***"Space for Diplomacy and Diplomacy for Space in Europe-China Relations".***



ESPI'S 2ND ANNUAL SPACE POLICY SUMMER SCHOOL

ESPI's ***Space Policy Summer School*** was held at the European University Institute (EUI), in Florence, Italy. Organised under the theme "Closing the competitiveness and resilience gap: the role of space", the school welcomed over 30 participants, including space agency personnel, diplomats, students, researchers and civil servants representing more than 20 countries across five continents.

Over the past year, EUI's partnership with ESPI has demonstrated the power of connecting academic insight with policy practice, enabling diverse professionals to engage deeply with space's contribution to Europe's competitiveness and resilience. We look forward to building on this strong foundation and exploring new avenues for collaboration in the years ahead.

Leonardo Meeus
DIRECTOR OF THE FLORENCE SCHOOL OF REGULATION
AT THE EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE

Family photo of the attendees of the 2nd ESPI Space Policy Summer School, organised in cooperation with EUI in Florence

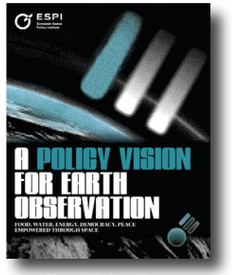
ESPI's key publications in 2025

REPORTS

An Initial Perspective on a European Space Strategy 2040

Rising Together?

Space Venture 2024



A Policy Vision for Earth Observation

Towards a Safe and Sustainable Cislunar Space

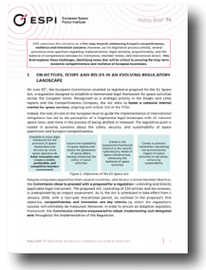
Observations and New Perspectives for Exploration in Times of Change

Talent in the European Space Sector

Blinded by the Light

Data Centres in Space

POLICY BRIEFS



A Reflective Look at the EU Space Act

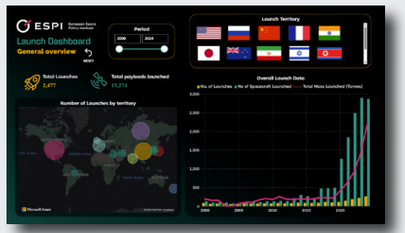
Simulating the Future of European Security

IRIS² Growing Up

Bundestag Election 2025

OTHER FORMATS

ESPI Insights
RELEASED MONTHLY



The ESPI Launch Dashboard

Special Perspectives and Event-related Key Takeaways

Green and Sustainable Societies

Key themes:

Policy impact of Earth observation | **Climate resilience and sustainability** | **Regional community-building**

A POLICY VISION FOR EARTH OBSERVATION

ESPI advanced its work on the policy value of Earth observation (EO) through *"A Policy Vision for Earth observation: food, water, energy, democracy, peace empowered through space"*, launched at the ESA Living Planet Symposium in Vienna, Austria. Across plenary interventions, thematic sessions and an ESPI–ISPRS event on climate action, ESPI highlighted the need to embed EO across Europe's full policy cycle and reframe it as a strategic investment for societal resilience.

ENGAGING SECTORIAL POLICY LEADERS AND STAKEHOLDERS

To develop the Policy Vision for Earth observation, ESPI and ESA co-hosted the Royal Society workshop *The Policy Value of Earth observation*, bringing together parliamentarians, former ministers and policy experts. The workshop identified concrete areas where EO can decisively support policy agendas, from energy and climate resilience to diplomacy, emergency management, agriculture and security. Participants emphasised co-development with users, clearer communication and deeper integration of EO into sectoral policies at a time when geopolitical pressures require purposeful, cross-sector collaboration.

REGIONAL AND INTERNATIONAL COMMUNITY-BUILDING

ESPI expanded its international engagement by building a community focused on EO applications in sub-Saharan Africa. This included co-organising, with ISPRS, the debate *Commercial Earth Observation for Boosting Policy Impact* during the Living Planet Symposium, bringing together African space leaders, ESA representatives, government officials, industry and civil society. Discussions underscored the need for tailored, locally co-created EO solutions and sustainable business models.

Europe must harness the full power of Earth observation to meet increasing environmental and societal challenges. We need sustained investments, deeper cooperation and faster uptake of space-based insights across all sectors and policies. Our ambition is clear: to make EO the engine of a more sustainable, resilient and innovative Europe.

Simonetta Cheli
DIRECTOR OF EARTH OBSERVATION PROGRAMMES AND HEAD OF ESRIN, ESA

Security and Defence

Key themes:

Space and defence industries | **Security community engagement** | **Space commands and Ministries of Defence (MoDs)**

(RE)CONVERGENCE OF SPACE AND DEFENCE INDUSTRIES IN A NEW SECURITY LANDSCAPE

ESPI advanced its strategic analysis of Europe's defence posture through *"Rising Together? The (Re)Convergence of Europe's Space and Defence Industries."* The report examined how traditional space companies are increasingly engaging in security and defence activities, while defence firms expand into the space domain through new programmes, acquisitions and investment. The study highlighted the tightening interdependence between industrial capacity and Europe's ability to meet its security objectives, particularly in a deteriorating geopolitical environment.

CONVENING EUROPE-WIDE DIALOGUE ON SPACE FOR SECURITY AND DEFENCE

ESPI strengthened its role as a European convenor of policy dialogue space for security and defence through a series of high-level events organised with ESA, POLSA and the Polish and Danish Presidencies of the Council of the EU. This included the conference *Space for European Resilience: Rising to the Collective Challenge*, and the 3rd ESA Security Conference in Warsaw. The topic of space for security & defence feature prominently in other ESPI events, including the 19th ESPI Annual Conference.

CONTINUED WORK WITH SPACE COMMANDS AND MINISTRIES OF DEFENCE

At the operational level, ESPI hosted the second edition of its Roundtable on Space Commands and Ministries of Defence in Vienna, Austria. Participants examined capability gaps, the role of exercises in fostering shared situational awareness and the integration of space into multi-domain operations. The exchanges highlighted growing recognition among military leaders that urgent, coordinated action is needed to strengthen Europe's collective preparedness, resilience and ability to respond to emerging threats in the space domain.

Reliable space services are crucial for the success on the modern battlefield. Therefore, in 2027, Austria's MoD is preparing and launching a set of military satellites to test and support Satcom, EO and PNT services, primarily with national industry assets and in cooperation with the Netherlands MoD. This step will also boost local industry as well as increase European Digital Sovereignty for critical data and space services for security operations.

Maj. Gen. Friedrich Teichmann
AUSTRIAN ARMED FORCES

Exploration and Science

Key themes:

European ambition in exploration | **Global shifts in exploration leadership** | **Cislunar safety and sustainability**

EXPLORATION AS A STRATEGIC ASSET

Space exploration is a driver of innovation, competitiveness and geopolitical influence. This message is at the core of ESPI's publication *"Observations and New Perspectives for Exploration in Times of Change"*, which underlined that exploration attracts talent, strengthens industrial capabilities and enhances Europe's ability to shape global alliances. Building on the previous recommendations from the *Revolution Space* report, the analysis highlighted that Europe's traditional position as junior partner has become increasingly unsustainable amid seismic geopolitical and economic shifts.

GLOBAL DIALOGUE ON LUNAR EXPLORATION IN A CHANGING STRATEGIC LANDSCAPE

ESPI strengthened international exchange on space exploration through cooperation with the Bertelsmann Foundation North America and participation in major global forums in the United States of America, Japan and India. Across these exchanges, ESPI contributed to high-level discussions on how geopolitical realignments, economic security and technological sovereignty are reshaping the future of exploration activities.

CISLUNAR SAFETY AS A STRATEGIC FRONTIER

ESPI's report *"Towards a Safe and Sustainable Cislunar Space"* assessed safety challenges in cislunar space such as situational awareness, space traffic management, debris mitigation, and end-of-life practices. The analysis found that missions remain insufficiently protected and argued that Europe must integrate cislunar safety into a broader exploration ambition. Strengthening capabilities in this area would de-risk future institutional and commercial missions and position Europe to shape governance structures for the lunar environment.

> The utilisation of space resources will be a key enabling factor across future in-space markets, including activities in Earth orbits, on the Moon and beyond. It will support Europe's strategic autonomy, international partnerships, and industrial competitiveness.

Mathias Link
DEPUTY CEO OF THE LUXEMBOURG SPACE AGENCY

Industry, Innovation, Finance, Workforce

Key themes:

Europe's industrial edge in space | **Talent and workforce resilience** | **Space-based digital infrastructure**

A NEW INDUSTRIAL VISION FOR EUROPE

ESPI advanced its work on Europe's industrial resilience through the publication of *"Blinded by the Light: Strategic Levers to Reclaim Europe's Industrial Edge in Space"*, a major study examining structural weaknesses, emerging competitive pressures and the future organisation of Europe's space industry. The analysis outlined pathways to strengthen industrial capacity, scale innovation and reinforce Europe's position within a rapidly evolving global market. As part of this work, ESPI hosted two dedicated industry workshops to test findings, gather practical insights and examine the industrial implications of future European strategic choices.

UNDERSTANDING EUROPE'S TALENT LANDSCAPE

Recognising the increasing workforce challenges across the European space sector, ESPI conducted a dedicated study called *"Talent in the European Space Sector: Bridging Gaps, Building Futures"* to analyse skills gaps, mobility barriers and the changing expectations of early-career professionals. The findings highlighted structural shortages in critical technical areas, increasing competition for specialised talent and the need for more coordinated approaches to training, retention and career development.

MEASURING INVESTMENT IN EUROPEAN SPACE VENTURES

ESPI's annual *"Space Venture"* report once again provided a detailed overview of global investment trends in 2024. Worldwide, the sector experienced a 6% increase in total investment compared to 2023, reaching €6.9 billion. For the first time since 2019, the United States attracted less than half of all global investment, while China and Europe together accounted for 50%, posting record highs.

> Resilient, sovereign connectivity is no longer optional, it is foundational. Europe must accelerate the deployment of secure, multi-orbit infrastructure to safeguard its strategic and economic interests.

Afke Schaart
EXECUTIVE VICE PRESIDENT INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS, EUTELSAT GROUP

Space as an Asset

Key themes:

EU Space Act | **European co-operation in space sustainability** | **Public launch data**

ANALYSIS OF THE EU SPACE ACT

In the policy brief *"Bold words, blurred lines: a reflective look at the EU Space Act"*, ESPI acknowledged the EU Space Act as a first attempt toward addressing Europe's competitiveness, resilience, and innovation challenges, but also highlighted several provisions that raised questions about implementation, legal certainty, proportionality, and the balance of competences between EU institutions, Member States, and international actors.

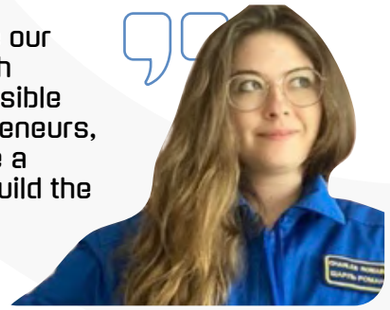
STRENGTHENING EUROPEAN COOPERATION IN SPACE SUSTAINABILITY

Ensuring that space remains accessible and usable in the long-term requires communication, coordination and cooperation among European stakeholders, especially at times of major policy and funding milestones ahead. To support this dialogue, ESPI hosted the workshop *"European Cooperation in Space Sustainability"* as part of the inauguration of ESPI's new Centre for Sustainability and Resilience (CSR), providing an independent platform for institutional and industrial stakeholders to engage together in policy dialogue.

LAUNCHING THE ESPI LAUNCH DASHBOARD

In 2025, ESPI published a new interactive dashboard on launches and spacecraft — a publicly accessible online tool that tracks and visualises global space launch activity. This dashboard is part of ESPI's ongoing mission to make space policy research and data accessible to a wider audience. With more actors entering orbit, and more launches occurring than ever before, more open and direct access to timely, transparent, and curated data is essential.

With the ESPI launch dashboard we make our internal launch database, curated through many years and regularly updated, accessible to decision makers, researchers, entrepreneurs, students or simply those curious, to have a common factual basis on which we can build the future, together.



Elizaveta Shashkova
ESPI RESEARCH FELLOW SECONDED BY CNES

Snapshot:

Research Themes in Action

In October, ESPI co-hosted the *"Space for European Resilience"* conference together with the Danish Presidency of the Council of the EU, the Danish Ministry of Higher Education and Science, and ESA, to discuss how space can strengthen Europe's collective security and resilience.

The first event of ESPI's newly created Centre for Sustainability and Resilience at ESPI (CSR), *"European Cooperation in Space Sustainability"*, was a closed-door workshop in March, facilitating a discussion on space safety and sustainability priorities among European actors ahead of upcoming institutional funding cycles.

Alongside the 40th Space Symposium in Colorado Springs in April, ESPI organised its first-ever event in the USA. Produced in partnership with Bertelsmann Foundation, this joint foresight workshop *"The Ways to the Moon"* addressed the future of lunar exploration with a spotlight on the transatlantic context.

CHAPTER THREE

Meet the team

Staff & culture

Quasi-International Organisation status

ESPI General Assembly

ESPI Members

ESPI mission, agenda & governance

ESPI Advisory council

On the rise
PUBLIC AWARENESS OF SPACE POLICY

ESPI Budget

Outlook
EUROPE IN SPACE – BUILDING STRENGTH

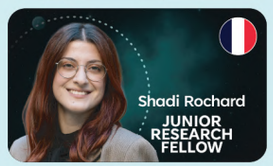
ABOUT US

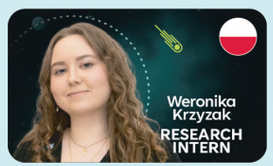
MEET THE TEAM

SECRETARIAT

MANAGEMENT

RESEARCH





Entered ESPI orbit in 2025

Left ESPI orbit in 2025

ENGAGEMENT

ADMIN & FINANCE

GENDER BALANCE

51%

49%

22 NATIONALITIES

13+ NEW FACES IN 2025

32 AVERAGE AGE

ASSOCIATES AND GLOBAL FELLOWS

- **Clelia Iacomino** — SENIOR ASSOCIATE FELLOW
- **Aoife van Linden Tol** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Ioana Petrescu** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Rorisang Moyo** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Daniel Porras** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Leyton Wells** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Ashok Venkateshmurthy** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Victoria Valdivia** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Yui Nakama** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW
- **Vinicius Guedes de Oliveira** — NON-RESIDENT FELLOW

VISITING RESEARCHERS

- **Dorthea Gradek** — VISITING RESEARCHER FROM NORSK UTENRIKSPOLITISK INSTITUTT (NUPI)
- **Takumi Kato** — VISITING RESEARCHER FROM JAPAN'S MINISTRY OF EDUCATION, CULTURE, SPORTS, SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY (MEXT)
- **Ellie Fox** — VISITING TRAINEE FROM FLINDERS UNIVERSITY
- **Claire Wilson** — VISITING TRAINEE FROM FLINDERS UNIVERSITY
- **Elisa Leoni** — VISITING RESEARCHER FROM THE UNIVERSITY OF TURIN
- **Seorim Lee** — VISITING RESEARCHER FROM KOREA AEROSPACE RESEARCH INSTITUTE (KARI)

STAFF & CULTURE

At ESPI, people are at the heart of our mission. Nurturing a motivated, diverse and international team remains a priority.

In 2025, ESPI welcomed a new wave of colleagues to its Vienna premises following a successful international recruitment campaign earlier in the year. The campaign attracted more than one thousand applications and further strengthened ESPI's profile as an international workplace.

By the end of the year, ESPI counted 45 staff members representing more than 20 nationalities.

In addition to new staff arrivals, ESPI continued to serve as a meeting point for visiting experts and global partners. Throughout the year, ESPI hosted visiting experts from Japan's Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology, the University of Turin, the Korea Aerospace Research Institute and Flinders University in Australia. Their contributions added fresh insight to ongoing projects and strengthened ESPI's international network.

22
different nationalities,
7 team members have dual nationality

45
team members*

22 male
49%

23 female
51%

13
new faces in 2025

**total throughout the year*

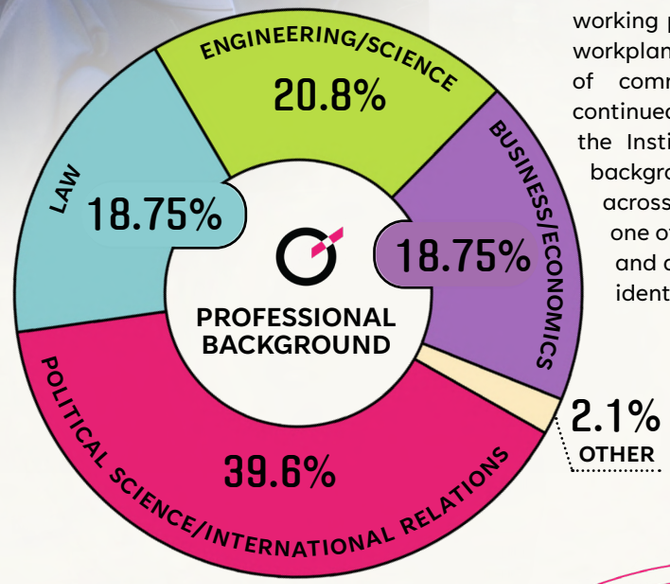
Over the past decade, I witnessed ESPI grow from a small team into a larger, highly diverse international organisation with employees from more than 20 nationalities, while becoming a thriving workplace built on purpose, trust and respect. I have also seen ESPI evolve into an organisation where people feel valued - and when people feel valued, they don't just work harder, but happier!

Lena Koeck
MANAGEMENT ASSISTANT & DATA PROTECTION OFFICER, ESPI

Giulia Pavesi, ESPI Lead on Security & Defence, speaking at the 17th European Space Conference

The Global Fellows Programme remained a valued part of ESPI's identity. Fellows from a variety of regions contributed to key research activities and helped foster dialogue between European and non-European stakeholders. Their presence continued to reflect ESPI's ambition to act as a global forum and to inspire new thinking across the international space community.

Throughout the year, ESPI maintained its commitment to a supportive and inclusive staff culture. Collaborative working practices across ESPI's workplan and a strong sense of community among staff continued to define daily life at the Institute. The diversity of backgrounds and perspectives across the team remained one of ESPI's greatest assets and a defining feature of its identity.



Quasi-International Organisation status

This year, ESPI was granted Quasi-International Organisation (QuIO) Status by its host nation, Austria, in accordance with the Austrian Headquarters Law, the most significant institutional milestone in the Institute's history. The granting of this status consolidates ESPI's evolution, formally recognising and strengthening the international role of the Institute , while reaffirming its non-profit character and commitment to the general good.

It positions ESPI alongside a distinguished group of QuIOs based in Austria, underlining the extraordinary nature of this designation and showcases that ESPI complies with a demanding set of requirement such as:

- **LEVEL OF STATE OR INTERNATIONAL ORGANISATION INVOLVEMENT** – there are currently 17 ESPI members representing states, international organisations or institutions that carry out tasks of these entities. ESPI activities are closely aligned with those of ESA as a founding member, the European Commission, and EUMETSAT.
- **IMPORTANCE OF INTERNATIONAL SCOPE** – ESPI currently has an international staff of more than 20 nationalities, and conducts research, engagement, and education activities across and beyond Europe.

RELATED EVOLUTIONS IN 2025

UPDATED GOVERNANCE
Update of ESPI Statutes to better reflect the QuIO requirements and strengthening the governmental character of its governance.

NEW DOMAIN
Change of ESPI's internet domain to espi.eu as a reflection of ESPI's pan-European identity.

FRESH LOOK
Introduction of a new visual identity carefully chosen to reflect our energy, dynamism and forward-looking mentality.

With this new ESPI chapter come new opportunities and along with them the responsibility to uphold the principles of our Quasi-International Organisation status. It is our privilege to pursue this goal with dedication, building on this special recognition and honouring it through our future achievements. Our thanks go to those who worked with us tirelessly behind the scenes, whose efforts made this journey possible. With our QuIO position granted, we will be able to look forward to the years ahead.

Evelyn Obernosterer-Egger
DIRECTOR OF FINANCE & ADMINISTRATION AT ESPI

Statement from the Chair of the ESPI General Assembly

Andreas Geisler

The year 2025 has again been a pivotal one for ESPI. In July, ESPI was proudly granted Quasi-IO status, a recognition that reinforces its role as a trusted platform for space policy and research across Europe. This milestone affirms the Institute's expertise and its unique position as a bridge between policymakers, diplomacy, industry and the scientific community.

ESPI also welcomed new members, expanding its network to 23 organisations, including Agencia Espacial Española and Xjenza Malta. The Institute continues to benefit from strong support across the membership, exemplified by a new and substantially increased funding contract from Austria, and the ESPI-LSA agreement. Special thanks go to Eutelsat for hosting the May 2025 General Assembly in Paris, where the updated ESPI statutes were adopted, aligning with the Quasi-IO status, further enhancing the Institute's organisational efficiency, and fostering closer collaboration among members.

A key highlight of the year was the conclusion of the new ESA-ESPI agreement, now established for the first time as a three-year framework (2026–2028) and approved by the ESA Council in December 2025. This agreement provides a reliable foundation for ESPI to expand its strategic analyses, studies, and activities, ensuring continued impact on European space policy.

Work also began on the ESPI Implementation Plan 2026-2030, intended to achieve the purpose of the Association for the period 2026-2030. In that respect the extraordinary General Assembly in December reflected on ESPI's increased activities, ongoing growth of staff, broadening engagement and impact, and the underlying budgetary basis.

I would like to express my deepest gratitude to the ESPI Director, the management and entire team, as well as ESA, BMIMI, and all ESPI members, for their commitment to the Institute's successful development. Together, we continue to advance European space policy with expertise, collaboration, and enduring impact – today and for the years ahead.

ESPI MEMBERS

Founding Members:

FFG Promoting Innovation.

esa

Supported by:

Federal Ministry Innovation, Mobility and Infrastructure Republic of Austria

AEE Agencia Espacial Española

European Commission

ASI Agenzia Spaziale Italiana

UK Space Agency

POLSA

XJENZA MALTA

PORTUGAL SPACE

EUMETSAT

Belgian Science Policy Office belspo

Norwegian Space Agency

DLR

cnes Centre National d'Études Spatiales

Schweizerische Eidgenossenschaft
Confédération suisse
Confederazione Svizzera
Confederaziun svizra

Swiss Confederation

Federal Department of Economic Affairs, Education and Research EAER
State Secretariat for Education, Research and Innovation SERI

rosa

LSA Luxembourg Space Agency

Regular Members

ThalesAlenia Space
a Thales / Leonardo company

arianespace
ariane GROUP

EXO LAUNCH

OHB

EUTELSAT GROUP

beyond gravity

Corporate Members

The rationale for the creation of ESPI is stronger today than it was when it was created, strengthening Europe's capacity to act strategically in an increasingly complex geopolitical and economic environment. By reinforcing its partnership with ESPI, ESA safeguards an indispensable capacity for independent thought and dialogue, one that strengthens the intellectual foundations of Europe's space strategy and reinforces the credibility of Europe as a global space power.

Eric Morel de Westgaver
DIRECTOR OF STRATEGY, LEGAL AND EXTERNAL MATTERS AT ESA

ESPI mission, agenda & governance

ESPI MISSION

FOR A STRONG EUROPE AS A PARTNER TO THE WORLD.

Founded in 2003, the European Space Policy Institute (ESPI) is Europe's independent think tank for space based in Vienna, Austria. Since July 2025, ESPI has operated as a **Quasi-International Organisation** within its host nation, Austria, in accordance with the Austrian Headquarters Law.

Working in a non-profit capacity, ESPI:

- Promotes European space policy on a global level
- Provides independent analyses, proposals, and recommendations on these strategic space issues to European decision-makers and institutions
- Raises public awareness of strategic space issues

ESPI AGENDA

ESPI works to fulfil its mission through its agenda, comprised of three overarching streams:

- **RESEARCH** – the cornerstone for ESPI's well-founded proposals to European decision-makers and institutions.
- **ENGAGEMENT** – a platform for dialogue in Europe and globally with diverse range of stakeholders.
- **EDUCATION** – supporting a European ecosystem that can nurture and retain a talented and skilled workforce.

ESPI'S GOVERNANCE

ESPI is governed by a **General Assembly,** which defines its general long-term guidelines and approves the annual report on activities, financial report and annual budget.

The **Advisory Council** provides medium-term recommendations with respect to the activities of the Institute.

ESPI is managed by the **Secretariat** composed of the Director and the Director of Finance and Administration and supported by ESPI's own staff as well as staff seconded by members.

Statement from the Chair of the ESPI Advisory Council
Etienne Schneider

Dear Readers,

Europe stepped up its space ambitions in 2025.

With Europe's space policy gaining unprecedented scale, and the increasingly visible political value of space globally, the need for independent policy advice to decision-makers and institutions, as defined in the mission statement of ESPI, becomes ever more important.

ESPI Advisory Council went through a major evolution in the past years, and its political profile has been strengthened with new members. It is not only space policy that matters, but increasingly how space enables other policy priorities. And I am thrilled to see increased involvement of Advisory Council members in ESPI's research, engagement and education activities.

The Advisory Council met twice in 2025, the second time in the format of an extraordinary meeting, to mark the inflection point of European space ambition and ESPI's role therein, following the major European announcements in 2025 and ESPI's evolution into a Quasi-International Organisation.

The Council strongly supports ESPI ambition in fostering international dialogues (with more active participation of ESPI members), strengthening Europe's international role. Our group of advisors also continues to advocate for increased engagement of ESPI towards high-level policy stakeholders and platforms. Simultaneously, building on the Institute's recognised research excellence, the Advisory Council encouraged the development of ESPI-driven tools and metrics to measure and benchmark European performance in space globally. The need for trusted data remains high.

Dear friends of ESPI,

We cannot allow Europe to fall behind as a secondary player compared to others. Europe must become a space power. Scale, speed and agility will matter and ESPI will continue to reinforce the momentum for space in Europe and support impactful policy action and the transformative potential of space for Europe's digital, security and competitiveness agendas.

ESPI European Space Policy Institute

ADVISORY COUNCIL 2025

ETIENNE SCHNEIDER
Chair, Former Deputy Prime Minister of Luxembourg

MAREK BANASZKIEWICZ
Former President of the Polish Space Agency

SAMANTHA CRISTOFORETTI
ESA Astronaut, member of the European Astronaut Corps

MAJ. GEN. MICHEL FRIEDLING (RET.)
Former French Space Commander

PEGGY HOLLINGER
International Business Editor at the Financial Times

FRITZ MERKLE
Former Chief Technical Officer at OHB

SINÉAD O'SULLIVAN
Economist at Harvard Business School's Institute for Strategy and Competitiveness

NIKLAS NIENAß
Former Member of the European Parliament

MARGIT MISCHKULNIG
Head of Dept. for Space Affairs at the Austrian Federal Ministry for Innovation, Mobility and Infrastructure

WALTHER PELZER
Director General of the German Space Agency at DLR

MAGALI VAISSIÈRE
Member of the Ministerial Space Steering Committee of France 2030

LORD DAVID WILLETTS
Chair of UK Space Agency and President of Resolution Foundation

ON THE RISE

PUBLIC AWARENESS OF SPACE POLICY

ESPI's institutional evolution in 2025 solidifies the Institute's mandate and ambition to "raise public awareness of strategic space issues" in connecting space and society and by promoting the general good.

As the transformative value of space grows across all sectors of society and economy, ESPI reinforces its work towards broader audiences and general public, creating new engagement platforms, outreach channels and cooperative endeavours.

ESPI's first-ever youth workshop for 14-year olds. Mission: collaborate to establish a new civilisation on an exoplanet.

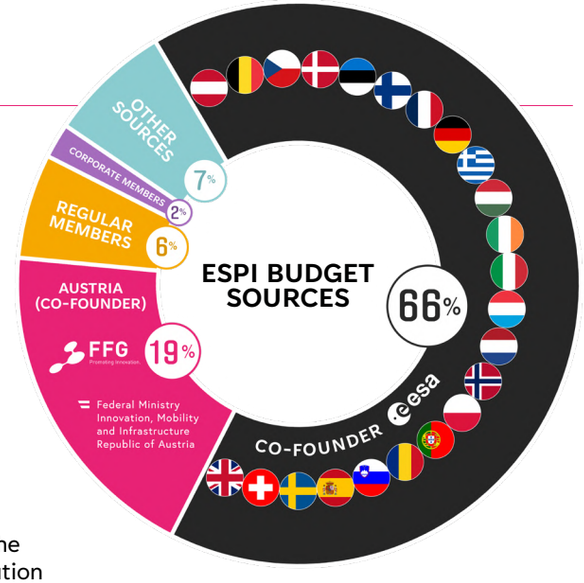
In 2025, ESPI once again demonstrated the effectiveness of its work, characterised by outstanding analytical capabilities and its ability to identify and highlight highly topical issues and challenges, thereby further strengthening its position within the global space community. Through the Centre for Sustainability and Resilience, ESPI fosters informed dialogue and builds understanding and trust between stakeholders in the space and non-space sector, with the underlying vision of helping to shape intergovernmental, multilateral and European discourse as well as **public debate**, and to accelerate decision-making processes. Thanks to ESPI, through in-depth analysis, collaboration and outreach, it helps to strengthen Europe's strategic position in space and raise awareness of a more sustainable and resilient future for all. With the current *"Fördervertrag"*, the BMIMI is underlining that it remains a trusted partner of the ESPI.

Margit Mischkulnig
HEAD OF DEPT. FOR SPACE AFFAIRS AT THE AUSTRIAN FEDERAL MINISTRY FOR INNOVATION, MOBILITY AND INFRASTRUCTURE

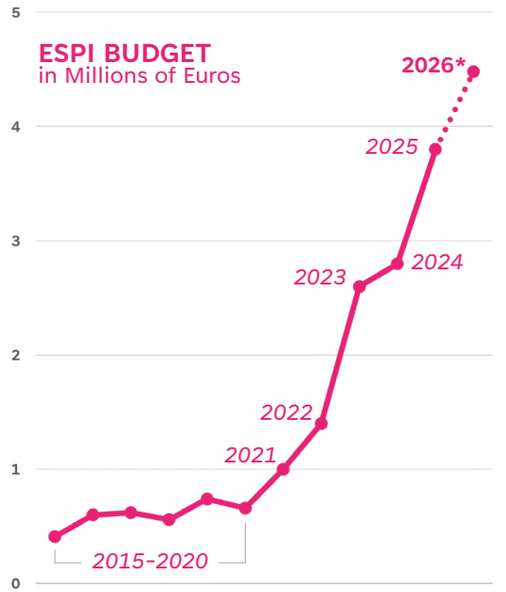
Budget

In 2025, the Institute continued its budgetary growth, increasing from €1.4 million in 2022 to € 3.8 million* in 2025, corresponding to 39.07% Compound Annual Growth Rate (CAGR).

This growth in 2025 was driven by increase of funding from our host nation Austria, which further strengthened its commitment to ESPI with a new four-year Subsidy Agreement. It was also supported by a new four-year agreement with the Luxembourg Space Agency, the continuation of existing agreements with ESA and ASI, the addition of two new members, and new cooperation and partnerships with European and international partners.



** ESA funding approved by all ESA Member States*
** 7 FTE directly seconded by members not included in budget figures*



** 2025 and 2026 data is indicative (not yet an approved financial statement), 2025 budget approved ESPI General Assembly*

These developments contribute to advancing the public-benefit objectives set out in the ESPI Statutes.

These developments support the objective of increasing and diversifying ESPI's funding base through a growing number of governmental entities, extending beyond its founding members. As a result, ESA's relative share of total funding decreased from 73% in 2024 to 66% in 2025. Funding from corporate members amounts to 2% as of 2025.

ESPI's General Assembly approved a total budget of €4.5 million for 2026. Together, these developments will allow for the sustainable operation of ESPI and safeguard its independence, thereby supporting the broader interests of Europe and its citizens.

OUTLOOK

EUROPE IN SPACE - BUILDING STRENGTH

After a year marked by renewed ambition across Europe's space sector, 2026 calls for a shared European vision that clearly articulates why space is critical to Europe's strategic, economic and geopolitical future.

Where the 2025 Outlook still questioned whether Europe would take concrete measures to implement a new level of ambition for increased sovereignty, the 2026 Outlook can be more confident. The European Union is advancing preparations for the Multiannual Financial Framework for 2028-2034 and an expected record allocation of €130 billion for defence and space. In parallel, ESA is preparing an Intermediary Ministerial Meeting in late 2026 focused on the future of exploration, also going beyond the Artemis mission. At the same time, Europe is about to reach and may soon exceed the benchmark of 0.15% GDP invested in space, as advocated in ESPI's 2040 Vision for Europe.

The coming years will be remembered as the time when Europe rebuilt its strength on Earth and in space, to bring a new level of capability and join forces with trusted global partners.

ESPI AGENDA - REACHING BEYOND SPACE

As highlighted in previous years, ESPI continues to strengthen its focus on political impact by promoting the policy value of space beyond the space sector itself, while reinforcing its institutional resilience at a time when independent analysis and open debate face increasing pressure. These challenges have intensified with the pervasive role of artificial intelligence and the growing influence of global digital giants on policy matters.

In 2026, ESPI will elaborate its plan for the coming 5 years on how to direct its strategy and operations to maximise the policy value and impact of space for society and economy, and how to strengthen ESPI's institutional resilience and independence. The ESPI 2030 Implementation Plan will be elaborated together with its members and support the implemention of the objectives of the ESPI 2040 Vision.

To carry the policy debate beyond space, ESPI will engage in major international fora, focusing on the benefits of space for the wider economy, security and defence, and as part of digital sovereignty. In addition, 2026 will see the inaugural edition of a new ESPI flagship event in partnership with the host nation and ESA, the **"Space Debate Europe"** in Madrid, Spain. It will act as a precursor of a future European space forum of high-level stakeholders impacting beyond the traditional space ecosystem.

Leveraging its new status as a Quasi-International Organisation, ESPI will further strengthen its resilience through expanded membership, new bilateral agreements and cooperation with its members. In this context, the 20th anniversary edition of the **ESPI Annual Conference in Vienna** will address Europe's aspirations for a new era.

Through these efforts, ESPI together with its members, advisors and partners will continue to act as a space for the brave, as part of a new "can do" attitude of Europe and the evolution of NewSpace.

ASPIRATIONS FOR A NEW ERA

In all of this emptiness— ... this thing we call the universe—you have this oasis, this beautiful place that we get to exist together.

Victor Glover Jr.
NASA Astronaut and crew member of the Artemis II lunar flyby mission, 4 April, 2026

Photo Credit: NASA

ESPI Team at the 19th ESPI Annual Conference "Europe as a Space Power" at Vienna City Hall, October 2025.

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ESPI

European Space Policy Institute